true. Evidently, when the Sultan was just a nobleman serving the Khiljis, he had suggested to the king that this would be a good place to build a city. The incumbent had sarcastically replied, ‘When you are Sultan, build it.’ Thus, it was one of the first building projects of the Tughlaqs.

Although overgrown and encroached upon, the extensive fortifications and other remains of Tughlaqabad are very impressive. Excavations in the 1990s revealed a secret passage connected to the palace, with elaborate passageways, hidden storage rooms and disguised entrance and exit. The exit is a small opening on the outer wall that looks like an innocuous drain. However, despite its rather solid appearance, the city was only occupied for a few years before being abandoned, probably because its water-supply was not secure.

Muhammad Tughlaq was the second sultan of the dynasty. He decided to shift the capital a thousand kilometers south to Daulatabad in 1326 AD. The fort held a strategic position on the Southern Road or Dakshina Path, and was ideally located for making raids into southern India. Therefore, the Sultan’s decision was understandable but for the fact that Muhammad insisted that every single inhabitant had to move with him. We have a macabre tale about how an old beggar was too feeble to make the journey. The Sultan had him tied to a cart and dragged along for forty days. Only his feet arrived in Daulatabad.

However, the Sultan soon changed his mind and the entire population was made to trudge back to Delhi. Muhammad now decided to expand the recently repopulated city and invited settlers from the rest of his empire and from Central Asia. He built a set of walls that connected the old city of Lal Kot with the Khilji fortress of Siri. This enclosed a very large area that would be the next city of Delhi—Jahanpanah. Note that the older cities continued to be inhabited. Even some parts of the abandoned Tughlaqabad were used for storage and to house garrisons. Thus, Jahanpanah was probably not entirely built up but contained open areas and even farming communities within the walls. Nonetheless, a massive new palace-complex was built. It is this patchwork of urban settlements that Ibn Batuta saw when he visited Delhi.